

charge of the situation."

The country's financial capital is today in a complete mess. The 11.9 million people who live here still grapple with poor roads, traffic congestion, and crumbling infrastructure. In addition, the city which for years has been known as the safest city, has become a nightmare for women. It is the failure of government agencies which is forcing citizen groups to take centre stage. Tired of having to deal with social and environmental issues on a regular basis, a number of Mumbaikars have initiated campaigns—either in the city or their communities—to grab the attention of the authorities. So be it curb-

RAJANISH KAKADE



LOUD 'N CLEAR: Youngsters seek attention through the Ghanta Naad movement—beating cutlery against BMC's proposal to lease open spaces

ing traffic jams, cutting down on power consumption or offering to assist BMC in razing encroachments, citizen bodies are actively participating in such movements to bring a change in their lives. Individual protests don't work anymore but mass movements can make a difference, believes Bhaskar Sawant, chairman of the Maidan Bachao Samiti. "When I, as an elected representative, highlight issues with

others, it has a greater impact. The government is forced to take notice," says Milind Deora, south Mumbai parliamentarian who led campaigns to save city's playgrounds.

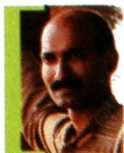
Similarly, to create awareness about the traffic congestion problem, a citizen group organised a car-free Sunday in December last year at Bandra to urge residents to leave their vehicles in the garage. With 11.2 lakh cars commuting

daily across the city, the average distance covered in an hour is not more than 12 km. "We must realise that every car on the streets is a problem, not a solution to our traffic woes," says Darryl D'Monte, president of the Bandra West Residents' Association.

Rather than waiting for the next assembly elections to displace a non-performing government, the citizens are forming pressure groups to sound

"There isn't a single authority that works responsibly, which is why people protest."

ADOLF D'SOUZA, CITIZEN ACTIVIST AND BMC CORPORATOR



the governing agencies. "The government delivery mechanism is failing on all counts. No one is accountable anymore. At such a time the only course of action for the public is to come out of their homes," explains Surendra Srivastava, volunteer of the Loksatta Movement—which is leading a fight for better governance. While the government may have lost count of its mangroves and the rate at which they are being illegally cleared to make way for development, Bandra's residents' associations are leading campaigns to protect their swamp cover. Srivastava believes that the root cause of such problems is the very structure of the government. While accountability lies with the elected representatives, authority is vested with the bureaucrats. "Democracy survives when common man takes active interest. A citizens' movement is taking shape to govern itself," he says.

Deora hails citizen participation but warns people against falling prey to celebrity-backed movements. "Solutions should be left to experts. Common people should merely highlight issues," says Deora. Mumbai's social campaigns are, however, no longer about celebrities but youngsters who are coming out in large numbers to lead from the front and take initiatives. The city-wide *Batti Bandh* (lights off) campaign is a case in point. It was led by a group of four young professionals who launched a campaign to mobilise Mumbaikars to switch off power in order to reduce global warming. The entire city may not have unplugged its appliances on December 15 last year, but the run-up to the event created awareness about the dangers of changing climate. D'Monte believes, "A movement, however small, is a seed planted in people's minds and goes a long way in changing the way they think".

As authorities continue to remain asleep at the wheel on social issues, growing groups of Mumbaikars are trying to shake them awake. ■

"Solutions should be left to experts and the public should merely highlight issues."

MILIND DEORA, MP AND CITIZEN ACTIVIST

